

Assertive Communication

Be heard — without shrinking or steamrolling

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Be heard — without shrinking or steamrolling

Assertiveness is the art of saying what you think, feel and want — clearly and with respect. Neither passive (you erase yourself) nor aggressive (you steamroll): in between, you stand up for yourself while respecting the other.

This guide helps you understand what stops you from asserting yourself, transform the thoughts that silence you, and express yourself with concrete tools.

Your intention

A situation where you'd like to assert yourself better: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Why you shrink (or explode)

Our ways of communicating are learned early. If asserting yourself was risky (authoritarian parents, the 'good kid' role), you learn to shrink — or, conversely, to explode when it's too much. Assertiveness can be relearned.

Understanding your default style (passive, aggressive, passive-aggressive) is the first step.

Example

Used to 'not making waves', Karim bottled up then exploded. Linking it to his history let him choose another mode.

Exercise — My default style

In which situations do I shrink? Explode? Turn passive-aggressive? Where does it come from?

What I didn't say

Note 3 recent things you kept quiet. What would you have wanted to say, calmly?

→ *My communication style is learned — so it can change.*

The thoughts that silence you

'If I say what I think, they won't like me', 'my opinion doesn't count', 'I'll start a conflict'. These thoughts push you into silence (or bottled-up anger).

Softening them opens space to speak calmly.

Example

Sure that 'giving an opinion = conflict', Awa voiced a disagreement calmly. The discussion was respectful, not a clash.

Assertiveness journal

Each time you stay silent, note: the thought · what you'd have wanted to say · an assertive version.

Reframe

Turn 'my opinion doesn't count' into a fairer thought.

→ *Asserting myself calmly isn't seeking conflict — it's respecting myself.*

Your needs have value

Assertiveness rests on a conviction: your needs, feelings and opinions matter as much as others'. You have the right to take your place.

Respecting yourself takes nothing from anyone.

Example

Léa dared to say 'I need us to talk about this' instead of swallowing it. Feeling legitimate changed everything.

Exercise — My rights

Write 5 rights you grant yourself (e.g. 'I have the right to say no', 'to change my mind', 'to have needs').

My value

A line to tell yourself before asserting: e.g. 'What I feel is legitimate.'

→ *I have the right to take my place. My needs matter.*

The tools of assertiveness

Asserting yourself is about phrasing. The 'I' message (I feel... when... I'd like...), the clear request, and holding against reactions are concrete tools that change everything.

You can acknowledge the other AND hold your position.

Example

Instead of 'you never listen to me', Sofia said 'I feel sidelined when I'm not consulted; I'd like us to talk about it'. The other heard her.

Exercise — My 'I' message

For your situation, write: I feel ____ when ____ . I'd like ____ .

The clear request

Phrase ONE precise, concrete, doable request (not a reproach).

→ *The 'I' message states my need without blaming — and it's heard better.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- The 'I' message: 'I feel... when... I'd like...' (instead of 'you...').
- Be concrete: ask for ONE specific behaviour, not a vague change.
- No need to apologize for asserting yourself: drop the 'sorry to bother you'.
- Breathe, speak slowly: calm makes assertiveness credible.
- Acknowledge the other AND hold your ground: 'I get your point, and here's mine'.
- Practise on easy situations before the big ones.

To fill in

Assertiveness journal

Date	The situation	What I kept quiet	My assertive version

My 'I' messages

Situation	I feel... when...	I'd like...

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Spot my default style.

Week 2 — Soften the thoughts that silence me.

Week 3 — Recognize my rights and value.

Week 4 — Use the 'I' message for real.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The situation where I assert myself:
- My 'I' message:
- My clear request:

TO CLOSE

Asserting yourself is respecting yourself — and it's heard better than you think.

Calmly, with respect — for you and for the other.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not a substitute for therapy. If you are going through a hard time, please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.